

Music and religion

Vivaldi inherited his father's talent on the violin, so a musical career beckoned, but religion was also to play an important role in his life. In 1693, he began training for the priesthood, perhaps influenced by an uncle who was a priest at the family's parish church.

“ I have heard him boast of composing a concerto faster than a copyist could write it down. ”

CHARLES DE BROSSES, FRENCH VISITOR TO
VENICE, 1739

Vivaldi was ordained a priest in March 1703, at the age of 25. Six months later, he was appointed violin teacher at the Ospedale della Pietà (Hospital of Mercy), a home for orphaned and abandoned girls—one of four such institutions in Venice. Music was part of the curriculum at these homes and by Vivaldi's time, the Pietà in particular was famous for the quality of its choir and orchestra. Leading composers wrote music especially for them and their concerts were eagerly attended.

In addition to teaching, Vivaldi's duties at the Pietà came to include composing, conducting, and buying instruments. He kept his association with the home almost until the end of his life. However, his other activities and travels meant that his services could not be exclusive, and his character seems at times to have